Reading Hymns in Four Parts

Understand each voice, sustain deliberately and make practical reductions.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

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1. Map soprano, alto, tenor and bass

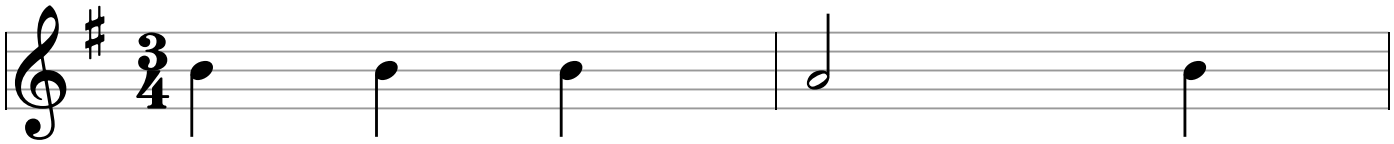
Follow a voice through the texture before reading every chord.

Map soprano, alto, tenor and bass

A four-part hymn is four musical lines. Soprano is usually the tune, alto sits beneath it, tenor lies above the bass, and bass supports the harmony. Begin by naming the first note of each line. Read the outer voices, then sing an inner voice while playing one outer line. Two-staff chord reductions in this course align supporting attacks with the melody; use the linked source for the original independent rhythms.

Practise · Soprano line: Jesus, the Very Thought of Thee: Soprano

Sing this voice, then play it alone. Notice its direction and its place in the harmony.



Opening example · 3/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Bass line: Jesus, the Very Thought of Thee: Bass

Sing this voice, then play it alone. Notice its direction and its place in the harmony.

Practise independently

Open the source score and trace one entire phrase in each voice. Say which voice moves by step and which repeats notes. Do not infer a voice only from which hand plays it.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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2. Bring an inner voice into focus

Hear the alto independently of the soprano.

Bring an inner voice into focus

An inner voice is easy to overlook because the ear follows the tune. Sing the alto slowly, then play it without the soprano. Notice repeated notes and small steps. When restoring the melody, let the alto remain connected and quieter. A finger substitution can connect repeated hand positions offline, but it should not distort the pulse.

Practise · Alto line: Abide with Me: Alto

Sing this voice, then play it alone. Notice its direction and its place in the harmony.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Two right-hand voices

Play the lower line alone first: E-F-E-D-E. Then restore the upper voice.

Practise independently

Sing the alto while playing only the bass offline. Then record both hands and check whether the inner line still sounds like a musical sentence.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

3. Read the tenor across the middle
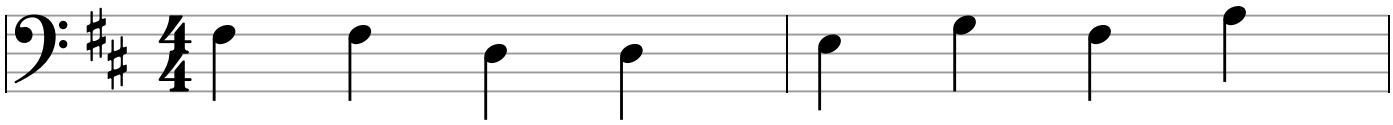
Track the line even when the hands redistribute notes.

Read the tenor across the middle

On a piano, the tenor may be played by the left hand or shared with the right to avoid an awkward stretch. The voice keeps its identity when the hand changes. Read the tenor as a melody, check its clef and octave, and compare it with the bass. Redistribution should preserve the important line and make movement easier; mark the hand change before practising.

Practise · Tenor line: Holy, Holy, Holy: Tenor

Sing this voice, then play it alone. Notice its direction and its place in the harmony.



Opening example · 4/4 · D · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Tenor and bass in one hand

Hear the upper left-hand notes as a line; keep the bass underneath them.

Practise independently

In the source opening, find any span that feels awkward. Try moving a tenor note to the right hand offline, then compare the sound and comfort. The app reference retains its printed hand assignment.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

4. Sustain one voice while another moves

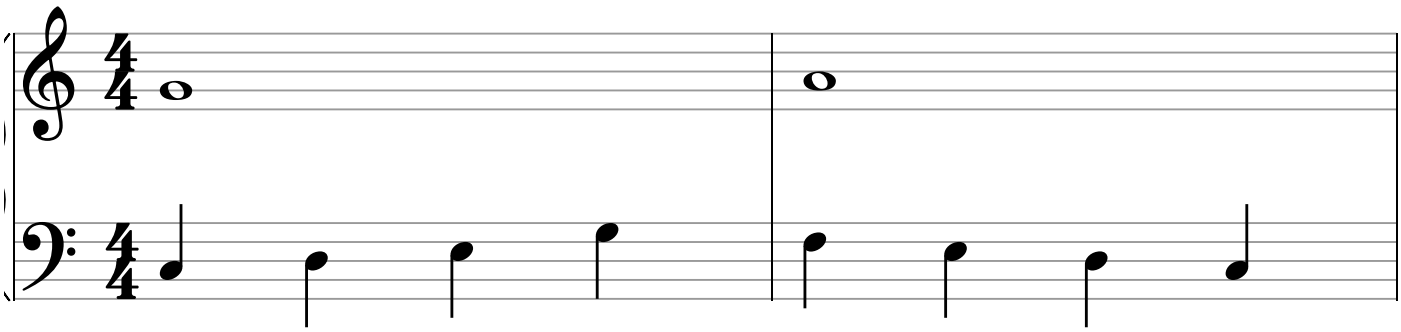
Release only the notes whose written values have ended.

Sustain one voice while another moves

Do not lift the entire hand just because one line changes. Practise one sustained note while another hand moves, then try the same idea within one hand away from the pitch checker. For the within-hand task, hold right-hand C5 with finger 5 while fingers 1-2-3 play E4-F4-G4-F4. Use separate silent preparation first and choose a smaller span if necessary. Pedal should not replace the finger coordination being practised.

Practise · Held soprano, moving bass

Keep the right-hand G sounding while the left line changes underneath it.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Held bass, moving melody

Change the left hand only at its written boundary.

Practise independently

Play the within-hand task offline without pedal and listen for uninterrupted C5. The app checks note attacks, so use your ears to judge whether that note actually remained held.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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5. Reduce a hymn without losing its identity
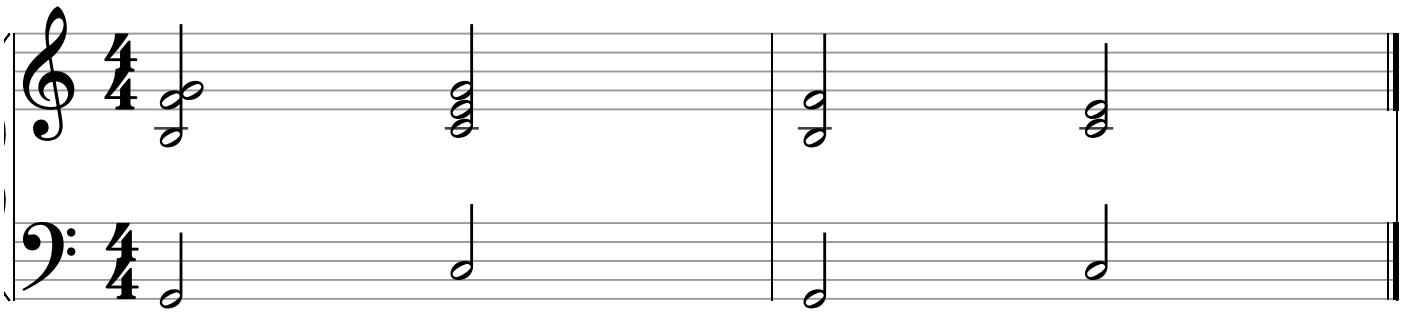
Preserve tune, bass and the notes that define the harmony.

Reduce a hymn without losing its identity

When a full chord is uncomfortable, identify what matters. Keep the melody and bass, then retain a third or seventh that explains the harmony. Remove a doubled note before removing the only defining third. Preserve a moving inner line when it carries an important resolution. Reduction is a deliberate musical choice; practise the printed reference first and compare your alternative offline.

Practise · Full chord then compact answer

Hear B-F resolve to C-E. The fifth can be omitted without losing the dominant-seventh pull.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Outer voices remain

Sing the missing middle before restoring it in your own arrangement.

Practise independently

Choose two bars from the hymn study. Make one comfortable reduction offline and explain each omitted note. Check that the melody, bass direction and cadence remain recognizable.

Use a short bar loop to repair a passage, then reconnect it to the phrase. The app checks the written pitches; Flow checks note-start timing. Listen for duration, tone, balance and pedal, and check physical ease yourself. Creative alternatives are practised away from the reference-score check.

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6. Holy, Holy, Holy: hear the inner lines

Sing the alto and tenor from the linked source before playing this melody-led reduction. Keep each line audible in your imagination while balancing the paired notes.

Prepare the score

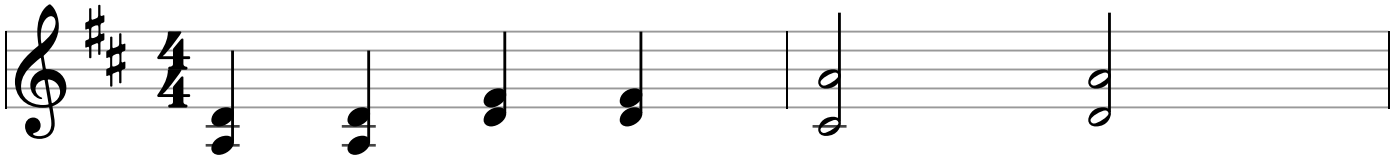
Sing the alto and tenor from the linked source before playing this melody-led reduction. Keep each line audible in your imagination while balancing the paired notes.

This is a melody-led piano reduction: supporting tones change with the melody. Source inner voices may be moved by octaves or rearticulated; study their original rhythms using the source score.

Preview the key, meter, pickup and ending. Prepare a stable fingering before adding speed.

Practise · Right hand: voice the melody

Read the upper line first. Where there are two notes, keep the top voice clearer. Release unnecessary pressure.



Opening example · 4/4 · D · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand: shape the support

Count aloud and play softly. Move the arm between positions; do not hold a wide stretch.

Practise · Join the opening

Sing the alto and tenor from the linked source before playing this melody-led reduction. Keep each line audible in your imagination while balancing the paired notes.

Practise · Holy, Holy, Holy: hear the inner lines

Sing the alto and tenor from the linked source before playing this melody-led reduction. Keep each line audible in your imagination while balancing the paired notes.

Make your own musical decision

Compare a source phrase with the reduction. Identify one inner rhythm that was aligned with the melody, then play the original voice alone offline.

Practise the alternative at your piano, then return to the written reference if using the app’s pitch check. Record yourself if possible and describe one audible improvement.

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7. Abide with Me: outer voices and support

Trace the bass direction and the soprano destination. Restore the supporting tones lightly and choose comfortable hand movements.

Prepare the score

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Preview the key, meter, pickup and ending. Prepare a stable fingering before adding speed.

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Count aloud and play softly. Move the arm between positions; do not hold a wide stretch.

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Trace the bass direction and the soprano destination. Restore the supporting tones lightly and choose comfortable hand movements.

Practise · Abide with Me: outer voices and support

Trace the bass direction and the soprano destination. Restore the supporting tones lightly and choose comfortable hand movements.

Make your own musical decision

Make a two-voice version offline, then restore one defining inner tone. Explain what you kept and why.

Practise the alternative at your piano, then return to the written reference if using the app’s pitch check. Record yourself if possible and describe one audible improvement.

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8. Jesus, the Very Thought of Thee: chorale reading

Present the complete hymn with a singing melody, a directed bass and quiet supporting notes. Understand the source voices as well as the piano reduction.

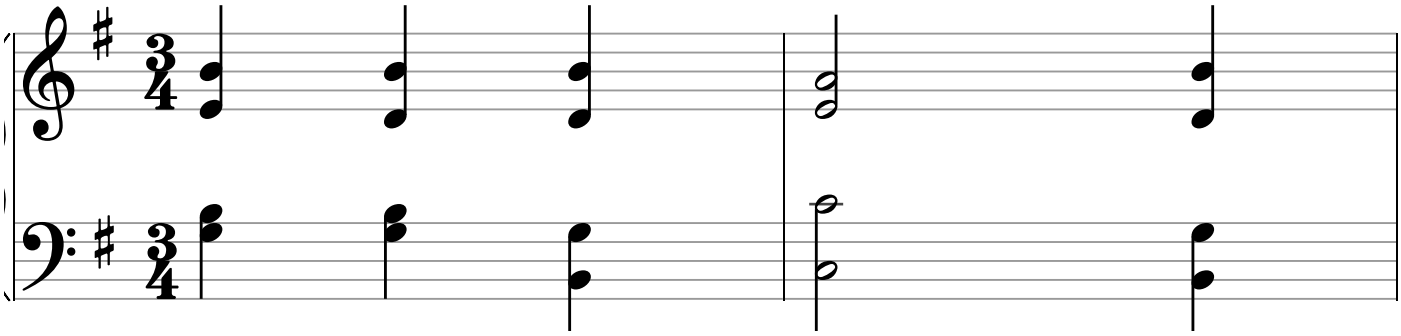
Prepare a complete performance

Present the complete hymn with a singing melody, a directed bass and quiet supporting notes. Understand the source voices as well as the piano reduction.

Choose a tempo at which you can finish comfortably. Mark three restart points, rehearse the opening and ending, then play without stopping. Afterwards assess pulse, clarity, phrasing, balance and recovery. Completion records a reference play-through, not a graded qualification or approval of an improvised arrangement.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Jesus, the Very Thought of Thee

Present the complete hymn with a singing melody, a directed bass and quiet supporting notes. Understand the source voices as well as the piano reduction.



Opening example · 3/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Your recital

Present the complete hymn with a singing melody, a directed bass and quiet supporting notes. Understand the source voices as well as the piano reduction.

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9. Abide with Me: chorale reading

Understand the source outer and inner voices, then present the complete melody-led piano reduction with a singing tune and quiet supporting notes.
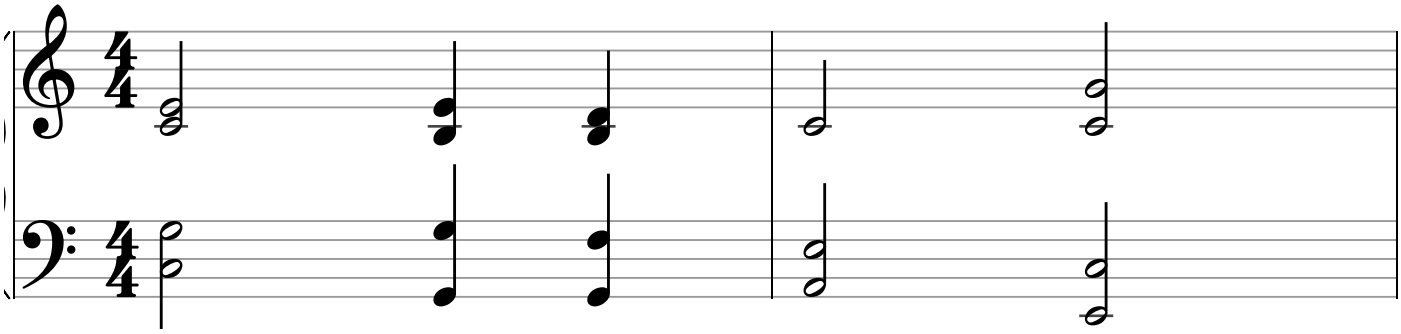
Prepare a complete performance

Understand the source outer and inner voices, then present the complete melody-led piano reduction with a singing tune and quiet supporting notes.

Choose a tempo at which you can finish comfortably. Mark three restart points, rehearse the opening and ending, then play without stopping. Afterwards assess pulse, clarity, phrasing, balance and recovery. Completion records a reference play-through, not a graded qualification or approval of an improvised arrangement.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Abide with Me

Understand the source outer and inner voices, then present the complete melody-led piano reduction with a singing tune and quiet supporting notes.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Your recital

Understand the source outer and inner voices, then present the complete melody-led piano reduction with a singing tune and quiet supporting notes.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Follow a voice through the texture before reading every chord.
- ☐ Hear the alto independently of the soprano.
- ☐ Track the line even when the hands redistribute notes.
- ☐ Release only the notes whose written values have ended.
- ☐ Preserve tune, bass and the notes that define the harmony.
- ☐ Perform my chosen recital with its stated musical goals, clear voicing, reliable pulse, comfortable movement and a deliberate ending.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
